

1.

**Cost reality:**

The API isn't free to run — Anthropic charges per message. For a makerspace with moderate traffic, probably **a few dollars a month** at most. Worth flagging for the board budget conversation.

**My recommendation for now:**

Don't change anything yet. Present what you have, let the board approve direction and hosting, *then* build the proxy to match whatever platform they choose. The chatbot code itself won't need to change — just where the API call goes.

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**What "free" means on the current AMS site:** The existing chatbot is likely a service like Tidio, Drift, or HubSpot — free tier means *they* are the product. Usually means:

- Limited responses per month
- Branding ("Powered by Tidio" etc.)
- They collect your visitor data
- Upsell pressure as traffic grows

**What Chip costs:**

- Anthropic API — pay per message, roughly **\$0.01–0.03 per conversation** at Sonnet rates
- A makerspace with modest web traffic might see **\$5–15/month** at most
- No third-party branding, no data harvesting, fully under AMS control

**How to frame it for the board:**

The free chatbot answers from a canned script. Chip actually *knows* the space — tools, membership, mission, values — and can hold a real conversation. The question isn't really free vs. paid, it's **what serves visitors better**.

### **A middle ground to propose:**

Start with a **monthly spending cap** on the Anthropic API — say \$20/month. If it hits the cap, Chip goes quiet until next month. Zero surprise bills, board stays in control.

### **Honest take:**

If budget is tight for a nonprofit, the free chatbot is defensible. But Chip is meaningfully better for first impressions — and first impressions are what convert curious visitors into members.

Worth letting Corny weigh in when he arrives June 15th.

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5:18 PM

**Claude responded: That's the right call — and you'll have a strong case.**

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### **Your best argument in the room:**

Chip already exists, already knows AMS inside and out, and the board can see it working the moment you open the laptop. That's a huge advantage over proposing something abstract. Seeing is believing.

### **A few things that will help your case:**

- **Demo it live** — open mission.html or index.html, click the  button, show Chip's greeting. Even without the API connected, the panel looks professional and the concept lands immediately
- **Show the current chatbot** side by side — the contrast between a generic canned-response widget and a knowledgeable AMS-specific assistant speaks for itself
- **The \$20/month cap idea** — gives the board a concrete, controllable number. Nonprofits respond well to defined limits
- **Mention it's already built** — no additional development cost, no vendor contract, no third-party data collection. The work is done